he in there? “Édouard, it’s Léa. Are you down there?”

Édouard appeared. “Why are you here?”

“I couldn’t sleep.”

“Go back to bed, Léa. You shouldn’t be here.”

“But I’m already awake.”

“This isn’t something you need to get involved in. André wouldn’t want that for you or Rose. The less you know, the better. Now, go.”

Defying him, she put her foot on the top step and crouching low, descended to the bottom rung. She could stand upright because the ceiling was high enough. The walls were a mix of dirt and chalk, like the soil. “Has this level always been in the house?”

“Yes. My father brought me down here for the first time when I was a boy. And his father did the same. Winemakers need good storage, and the limestone makes digging and hollowing out easy.”

She glimpsed four oak barrels stacked on their sides. “You’re making wine?”

He nodded and pointed to the other side of the stairs, where demijohns full of wine lined the floor. “I made two hundred bottles of wine last year under Weinführer Brucker’s nose without him knowing and sold them all.” He grinned. “Now, all that’s left is to deliver the demijohns to the black marketeer. I ran out of bottles, but he’s willing to take the jugs and do the bottling himself.”

Léa didn’t know what to say.

“Keep it to yourself. Not a word to anyone. The Weinführer already suspects I’m making wine on the side but he has no proof.”

All she could think about was the risk he was taking. What would happen to him if he were caught? What would happen to them all if he were caught?

His gaze was locked on hers and despite her unease, she nodded. “Of course. I won’t tell anyone.”

Édouard motioned to the stairs. “Go back to the house. You don’t need to be a part of this.”

“Is anyone helping you now that André’s gone?”

“I can get by fine on my own.” He smiled. “This vintage is some of my finest with caramel and smoky notes from the oak barrels. I got three times the pre-war price!” He laughed. “I tried to act disappointed when the